

Olympiad Test Paper — Social Science (Class 7) — Paper 4

Chapter 15: Empires and Kingdoms: 6th to 10th Centuries

Paper 4 — (progressively harder)

Subject	Social Science (NCERT Class 7)
Chapter	15 — Empires and Kingdoms: 6th to 10th Centuries
Total Questions	60 (Multiple Choice, single correct)
Maximum Marks	240
Suggested Time	90 minutes

Marking scheme: +4 for each correct answer · -1 for each wrong answer · 0 if unattempted.

Instructions: Each question has four options (A), (B), (C), (D); exactly one is correct. Classic traps: the post-Gupta age was creative (temples, universities, the rules of zero, Bhakti), not a 'dark age'; the Arabs took only Sindh in 712 CE and were held to that foothold, never 'most of India'; the Tripartite Struggle for Kanauj was three-sided (Palas, Gurjara-Pratiharas, Rashtrakutas), not two-sided; the caste/jati system was flexible and regionally varied, not rigid; a king ruled in layers (samantas plus self-governing sabhas), not directly over every villager; a single traveller's account (Xuanzang) must be cross-checked against inscriptions and coins; match dynasties to monuments (Rashtrakutas-Ellora, Pallavas-Mahabalipuram, Palas-Nalanda/Vikramashila), not swapped. Do not write on this paper — mark answers on your answer sheet.

1. A museum panel reads: 'From about 600 to 1200 CE, no single throne commanded the whole subcontinent, yet temples, universities and new mathematics flourished.' The single idea this best supports is that the age combined:

- (A) one all-India empire with deliberately suppressed art and learning
- (B) the complete absence of organised states with a thriving culture imposed from outside
- (C) political fragmentation among many regional kingdoms with a vigorous cultural flowering
- (D) unbroken foreign rule over the whole land with no Indian patrons of culture

2. A student lists four 'achievements that disprove the dark-age label': the rules of zero, the Bhakti hymns, the Buddhist universities, and the Arab conquest of Sindh. Which item does NOT belong on the list?

- (A) the Arab conquest of Sindh
- (B) the rules of zero
- (C) the Bhakti hymns
- (D) the Buddhist universities

3. The chapter calls the post-Gupta centuries creative rather than a 'dark age'. Which line of reasoning most directly supports that verdict?

- (A) a single emperor unified the subcontinent and personally ordered every cultural work
- (B) foreign rulers brought all the art and learning of the period from outside India
- (C) there was constant warfare and nothing of lasting value was produced
- (D) monuments, universities, a major advance in mathematics and a new devotional movement all appeared in these very centuries

4. Why does the existence of many competing kingdoms, rather than one empire, help explain the rich art of this age?

- (A) fragmentation always halts building and learning until unity returns
- (B) only an empire can ever fund temples, so the art must have come from foreign rulers
- (C) the kingdoms agreed to build nothing so as to save resources for war
- (D) rival courts each acted as patrons, sponsoring temples and scholars to outshine their neighbours

5. A textbook claims 'the only thing that mattered between the Guptas and 1200 CE was war, so the period was barren.' The best single rebuttal is that:

- (A) the period in fact saw no warfare at all between kingdoms
- (B) the same period gave Nalanda and Vikramashila, the Kailasa temple, Brahmagupta's zero and the Bhakti saints
- (C) a single peaceful empire governed the whole land throughout
- (D) all cultural life of the period was created by Arab rulers in Sindh

6. The period roughly 600-1200 CE is best characterised politically as:

- (A) a subcontinent of many strong, competing regional kingdoms with no single overarching empire
- (B) one vast empire that stretched unbroken across the whole subcontinent
- (C) a land with no organised kingdoms or states of any kind
- (D) a region governed in its entirety by Arab administrators from Sindh

7. Two students argue. One says 'no empire means cultural collapse'; the other says 'no empire, yet culture thrived.' The chapter's evidence sides with the second student chiefly because:

- (A) the records show that all building stopped until an empire was re-established
- (B) the records show great temples, learning and new religious ideas precisely during the era of many kingdoms

- (C) the records prove that culture survived only in the one province ruled by Arabs
- (D) the records show a single emperor secretly held the whole land together

8. Harshavardhana's rise (about 606 CE) and the Arab capture of Sindh (712 CE) are placed on a timeline. The correct relationship is that:

- (A) the Arab capture of Sindh came first, before Harsha's rise
- (B) Harsha's rise came roughly a century before the Arab capture of Sindh
- (C) both events fell in the same year, 712 CE
- (D) Harsha's rise came in 1206 CE, long after the capture of Sindh

9. After Harshavardhana, the clearest sign that no successor inherited his command of the north is that:

- (A) one of his heirs ruled the whole north unchallenged for centuries
- (B) rival regional powers had to contest Kanauj in the long Tripartite Struggle
- (C) the Arabs immediately overran the entire north Indian plain
- (D) all the northern kingdoms peacefully merged into a single state

10. Xuanzang, a Chinese Buddhist pilgrim, wrote a glowing account of Harsha's India and especially of Nalanda. The fact that he was a Buddhist monk most helps explain why his account:

- (A) dwells with special admiration on Buddhist centres of learning
- (B) ignores religion entirely and describes only battles
- (C) praises only the Arab rulers of distant Sindh
- (D) was composed in the Tamil language of the far south

11. A careful historian reading Xuanzang's praise of Harsha's just rule should:

- (A) accept every detail as exact, since an eyewitness can never be mistaken
- (B) treat it as one valuable source and cross-check it against inscriptions, coins and local records
- (C) reject it entirely, on the ground that foreign visitors always lie
- (D) use it as the sole permitted source and set aside all Indian evidence

12. Why is it misleading to say 'Xuanzang's single account proves Harsha's India was prosperous'?

- (A) Xuanzang never actually set foot in India
- (B) prosperity is something no source could ever reveal
- (C) one observer can be partial or mistaken, so his claims need testing against independent evidence
- (D) only coins, and nothing else, can establish any historical fact

13. Harshavardhana ruled the north of this age from his capital at:

- (A) Vatapi (Badami) in the Deccan
- (B) Kanchi in the Tamil region
- (C) Ellora, beside the Kailasa temple
- (D) Kannauj

14. Assertion: After Harsha, the north long lacked a single dominant emperor. Reason: This vacuum is why several regional powers fought the Tripartite Struggle. Which is correct?

- (A) both statements are true, but the reason does not explain the assertion
- (B) the assertion is true but the reason is false
- (C) both statements are true, and the reason correctly explains the assertion
- (D) the assertion is false but the reason is true

15. The contest is called the 'Tripartite Struggle' specifically because the rivalry for Kanauj involved:

- (A) two powers: the Palas and the Pratiharas only
- (B) three powers: the Cholas, Pandyas and Cheras of the Tamil south
- (C) three powers: the Palas, the Gurjara-Pratiharas and the Rashtrakutas
- (D) three powers: the Chalukyas, Pallavas and Guptas

16. Why did the Rashtrakutas of the Deccan repeatedly march far north to fight over Kanauj?

- (A) Kanauj was the only place in the subcontinent that produced gold
- (B) the Rashtrakutas had no kingdom of their own and needed any city to rule
- (C) Kanauj was a southern seaport the Rashtrakutas needed for ocean trade
- (D) holding Kanauj was a prized symbol of supremacy over the north, worth contesting even from a distance

17. That the Tripartite Struggle dragged on for generations without any one power keeping Kanauj for good best shows that the age was one of:

- (A) a single unbeatable empire ruling over all of India
- (B) a balance of several strong regional kingdoms, none able to dominate the rest for long
- (C) total peace with no political rivalry whatever
- (D) foreign Arab rule extending over the whole north

18. By guarding the north-west frontier, the Gurjara-Pratiharas had a wider consequence for the period: they:

- (A) opened the way for the Arabs to conquer the whole of north India
- (B) ended the Tripartite Struggle by handing Kanauj to a rival
- (C) helped block Arab expansion beyond Sindh, keeping Arab rule confined to that foothold
- (D) founded the Buddhist university of Nalanda far to the east in Bengal

19. Which list correctly orders three powers from north-west to east across the subcontinent?

- (A) Palas (north-west), Pratiharas (Deccan), Rashtrakutas (east)
- (B) Rashtrakutas (north-west), Palas (Deccan), Pratiharas (east)

- (C) Gurjara-Pratiharas (north-west), Rashtrakutas (Deccan), Palas (Bengal in the east)
- (D) Pallavas (north-west), Cholas (Deccan), Cheras (east)

20. Two students debate whether the Kanauj contest was two-sided or three-sided. The decisive point in favour of three-sided is that:

- (A) only the Palas and Pratiharas ever sent armies toward Kanauj
- (B) the Rashtrakutas of the Deccan repeatedly intervened alongside the Palas and Pratiharas
- (C) the Cholas of the Tamil south were the third contestant for Kanauj
- (D) the Guptas remained one of the three powers fighting for Kanauj

21. A historian writes that no single power held Kanauj permanently 'because the rivals were too evenly matched.' This explanation best fits the idea that the age featured:

- (A) one dominant empire that could crush all challengers at will
- (B) a complete absence of any organised military force
- (C) a single foreign ruler controlling all three contending dynasties
- (D) several roughly equal regional kingdoms in a shifting balance of power

22. Match each dynasty to the monument it is most associated with: Rashtrakutas, Pallavas, Palas.

- (A) Rashtrakutas - Nalanda; Pallavas - Ellora; Palas - Mahabalipuram
- (B) Rashtrakutas - Mahabalipuram; Pallavas - Nalanda; Palas - Ellora
- (C) Rashtrakutas - Mahabalipuram; Pallavas - Ellora; Palas - Nalanda
- (D) Rashtrakutas - Kailasa temple at Ellora; Pallavas - rathas of Mahabalipuram; Palas - university of Nalanda

23. What makes the Kailasa temple at Ellora an extraordinary achievement, and why is it called 'monolithic'?

- (A) the entire temple was carved downward out of one mass of living rock, not built up from separate blocks
- (B) it was assembled from thousands of imported marble bricks
- (C) it was the largest wooden temple ever raised in the period
- (D) it was the first temple in India cast entirely in iron

24. A 'ratha' at Mahabalipuram is best described as:

- (A) a shrine cut from rock to resemble a chariot
- (B) a self-governing village assembly
- (C) a large man-made reservoir for storing rainwater
- (D) a subordinate ruler who paid tribute to an overlord

25. Compared with the Pallava rathas of Mahabalipuram, the Rashtrakuta Kailasa temple at Ellora is especially noted for being:

- (A) built of fired brick rather than cut from stone
- (B) a single, much larger temple carved downward from one rock mass

- (C) a Buddhist university rather than a temple
- (D) a chariot too small for anyone to enter

26. Both the Kailasa temple and the Mahabalipuram rathas are cited together as evidence that builders of this age had mastered:

- (A) the printing of illustrated books on paper
- (B) the art of carving temples directly out of solid rock
- (C) the minting of paper currency for long-distance trade
- (D) the casting of large structures in steel

27. The Palas of Bengal are singled out in the chapter mainly for their patronage of:

- (A) great Buddhist centres of learning, especially Nalanda and Vikramashila
- (B) the rock-cut rathas of Mahabalipuram
- (C) the monolithic Kailasa temple at Ellora
- (D) the Arab settlement established in Sindh

28. Vikramashila admitted students only after a 'dvarapandita' (gate-scholar) had examined them. The best inference about the university is that it:

- (A) admitted anyone who turned up, with no selection at all
- (B) was actually a military camp rather than a place of study
- (C) taught only the rules of zero and nothing else
- (D) kept high standards by testing applicants before admission

29. The Pallavas of Kanchi and the Chalukyas of Vatapi (Badami) are remembered partly for:

- (A) a firm alliance that united the whole south under one throne
- (B) ruling jointly over Bengal and its Buddhist universities
- (C) a long-running rivalry between two southern powers, alongside the temple art each patronised
- (D) leading the Arab armies that conquered Sindh

30. Which pairing of a southern power with its correct capital region is right?

- (A) Pallavas - Kanchi in the Tamil region; Chalukyas - Vatapi (Badami) in the Deccan
- (B) Pallavas - Vatapi in the Deccan; Chalukyas - Kanchi in the Tamil region
- (C) Pallavas - Bengal; Chalukyas - Kashmir
- (D) Pallavas - Sindh; Chalukyas - Kanauj

31. Alongside the Chalukyas and Pallavas, three ancient Tamil dynasties revived in this age. They were the:

- (A) Palas, Pratiharas and Rashtrakutas
- (B) Mauryas, Shungas and Satavahanas
- (C) Hunas, Shakas and Kushanas
- (D) Cholas, Pandyas and Cheras

32. The revival of the Cholas, Pandyas and Cheras shows that, in this age, the Tamil south was:

- (A) empty of any kingdoms or organised states
- (B) ruled in its entirety by the Arabs of Sindh

- (C) once more a centre of strong kingdoms, temples and trade
- (D) absorbed into the Pala empire of distant Bengal

33. An exhibit labels a tall stone shrine 'a monolithic ratha-style temple of the Tamil coast'. The dynasty most likely responsible is the:

- (A) Rashtrakutas
- (B) Palas
- (C) Gurjara-Pratiharas
- (D) Pallavas

34. Both the Palas (supporting Nalanda) and the early Cholas (recording village rules at Uttaramerur) illustrate the same broad point, namely that:

- (A) only one northern empire ever patronised any culture
- (B) kingdoms of this age destroyed schools and assemblies
- (C) all cultural and civic life depended on the Arab rulers of Sindh
- (D) different regional kingdoms each fostered learning and institutions in their own way

35. A king of this age is said to rule through 'samantas'. This means his authority over outlying regions was exercised by:

- (A) directly appointed salaried officials reporting daily to the capital
- (B) elected representatives chosen in a nationwide vote
- (C) subordinate rulers who governed in his name in return for tribute and troops
- (D) foreign Arab governors sent up from Sindh

36. Because samantas held real local power and could shift their loyalty, the most important effect of ruling through many of them was that:

- (A) a king's real strength depended on keeping his subordinates loyal, so authority was indirect and layered
- (B) the king came to administer every single village in person
- (C) samantas owed the king no duties of any kind
- (D) royal power reached each individual through a national vote

37. Royal power in this age is best described as flowing:

- (A) directly from the king to every individual villager with no go-betweens
- (B) downward through many hands, from king to samantas to village assemblies, not straight to each villager
- (C) only from foreign Arab rulers based in Sindh
- (D) upward from a single elected national parliament

38. If a historian wanted firsthand evidence about how a Chola village chose the members of its assembly, the best source would be:

- (A) the Uttaramerur inscriptions
- (B) Xuanzang's travel account of Harsha's India

- (C) Brahmagupta's rules for calculating with zero
- (D) Kalhana's Rajatarangini on the dynasties of Kashmir

39. A 'land grant' recorded on a copper plate in this age typically:

- (A) confiscated all land from villagers and gave them nothing in return
- (B) gave land, often with tax rights over it, to a person, temple or community, creating a class of landholders
- (C) was a devotional Tamil poem addressed to a deity
- (D) described how to carve a chariot-shaped temple from rock

40. That villages ran many of their own affairs through a sabha shows political power in this age included:

- (A) no government at all below the level of the king
- (B) rule exercised only by foreign powers
- (C) real local self-government beneath the kings
- (D) a single national parliament governing every village

41. Which pairing of a term with its meaning is correct?

- (A) sabha - a subordinate ruler; samanta - a village assembly
- (B) sabha - a chariot-shaped temple; samanta - a water reservoir
- (C) sabha - a devotional poem; samanta - a Chinese pilgrim
- (D) sabha - a village assembly; samanta - a subordinate ruler

42. A 'tank' (Tamil eri) built and maintained in a Chola village was a:

- (A) war chariot used by cavalry in battle
- (B) Buddhist monastery for travelling monks
- (C) subordinate ruler who paid tribute to the Cholas
- (D) large man-made reservoir storing rainwater for irrigation and daily use

43. Merchant guilds, busy market towns and active trade routes in this period are best read as evidence that the post-Gupta economy was:

- (A) active and prosperous, contradicting any idea of total decline
- (B) completely destroyed and reduced to ruin
- (C) limited to silent barter with no organised trade
- (D) wholly controlled by Arab merchants from Sindh

44. Land grants, merchant guilds and irrigation tanks taken together best show that the age combined:

- (A) total economic ruin and the end of farming
- (B) a productive economy with deliberate management of land and water
- (C) a complete absence of trade or money
- (D) a society with no landholders of any kind

45. An inscription records that a guild repaired a village tank and a king's grant assigned its revenues to a temple. The best single conclusion is that:

- (A) the village had no trade and no organised water supply
- (B) trade bodies, irrigation works and grants worked together in a managed and prosperous economy
- (C) the economy had collapsed and no institutions survived
- (D) all land and water were controlled directly by Arab governors

46. Nalanda and Vikramashila drew students and monks from distant lands across Asia. The best inference is that, in this age, India was:

- (A) cut off from all contact beyond its own borders
- (B) without any institutions of higher study
- (C) ruled in its entirety by foreign Arab governors
- (D) a respected centre of learning connected to a wider world by travel and exchange

47. Why does the chapter point out that the caste (varna-jati) system of this age was flexible rather than completely fixed?

- (A) there were in fact no jatis at all in this period
- (B) every person in India belonged to a single, identical group
- (C) status could change over time and varied by region, as when the Palas are said to have risen from a humbler background to kingship
- (D) caste had been abolished entirely by royal decree

48. The Kayasthas are given in the chapter as an example of how, in this age:

- (A) a profession or occupation could harden into a distinct jati over time
- (B) a jati once formed could never change in any way
- (C) foreigners came to rule the whole of India
- (D) temples were carved out of single blocks of rock

49. That jatis multiplied and some families shifted status across this period indicates that the social system was:

- (A) perfectly simple and absolutely unchanging
- (B) completely abolished in this age
- (C) complex and changing, not frozen for all time
- (D) identical in every region of India

50. A student claims 'caste in this age was rigid and identical everywhere.' The best correction the chapter supports is that caste was:

- (A) indeed rigid, but at least it differed from one region to another
- (B) flexible and regionally varied, with some families and groups changing status over time
- (C) abolished completely, so the question of rigidity does not arise
- (D) the same single group for everyone across the whole subcontinent

51. The chapter notes that, in this age, some queens and women:

- (A) were entirely absent from public life
- (B) each ruled the whole subcontinent on her own
- (C) were forbidden any role outside the home
- (D) held real influence and exercised power in public affairs

52. How did the Bhakti way of worship differ from the older, formal Vedic tradition?

- (A) it relied entirely on grand public sacrifices performed by priests
- (B) it was closed to everyone except kings and nobles
- (C) it was a foreign religion brought by the Arabs into Sindh
- (D) it stressed personal, loving devotion to a deity and was open to people of all backgrounds

53. The Alvars and the Nayanars, the early Tamil Bhakti poet-saints, are correctly distinguished as:

- (A) Alvars devoted to Vishnu, Nayanars devoted to Shiva
- (B) Alvars devoted to Shiva, Nayanars devoted to Vishnu
- (C) both groups devoted only to the Buddha
- (D) Alvars Chinese pilgrims, Nayanars Arab generals

54. Brahmagupta, a mathematician of this age, is remembered for:

- (A) setting down rules for calculating with zero as a number
- (B) writing the Rajatarangini, a history of Kashmir
- (C) leading the Arab conquest of Sindh
- (D) founding the twelve Alvar poet-saints of the south

55. That an Indian scholar set out the rules for zero in this very period is most often used to refute which mistaken claim?

- (A) that the Arabs conquered only Sindh in 712 CE
- (B) that the Tripartite Struggle was fought over Kanauj
- (C) that the post-Gupta age was an intellectually barren 'dark age'
- (D) that the Pallavas built the rathas of Mahabalipuram

56. 'Epigraphy' helps historians of this age because it is the study of:

- (A) coins and the metals from which they are struck
- (B) the movements of the stars and planets
- (C) inscriptions carved on stone or metal, such as copper-plate grants and temple records
- (D) old travel diaries written by foreign visitors

57. A copper-plate grant praises a king lavishly, while a neighbouring kingdom's inscription claims it defeated that same king. A careful historian concludes that:

- (A) the first inscription must be wholly true because it is longer
- (B) both inscriptions are worthless and should be ignored

- (C) each inscription may be biased toward its own ruler, so the truth lies in weighing both against other evidence
- (D) whichever inscription is older is automatically correct

58. The Rajatarangini is unusual among early Indian texts because it is:

- (A) Kalhana's twelfth-century work setting down the history of Kashmir's dynasties in chronological order
- (B) Brahmagupta's treatise on the rules of zero
- (C) a Tamil devotional poem composed by an Alvar
- (D) an Arab official's account of the conquest of Sindh

59. Which single statement is fully accurate about the Arab presence in the subcontinent in this age?

- (A) the Arabs held Sindh from 712 CE but were kept from expanding much further by Indian resistance
- (B) the Arabs conquered the whole of India and ruled it directly
- (C) the Arabs were defeated and never held any territory in the subcontinent
- (D) the Arabs ruled Bengal and the Tamil south but never held Sindh

60. A student writes: 'After the Guptas India fell into a dark age, the Arabs conquered most of it in 712, and the Tripartite Struggle was a two-power fight.' How many of these three statements are wrong, and what is the corrected picture?

- (A) none are wrong: the age was dark, the Arabs took most of India, and two powers fought
- (B) all three are wrong: the age was creative, the Arabs took only Sindh, and the struggle was three-sided
- (C) only one is wrong: just the claim about the Tripartite Struggle
- (D) only the dark-age claim is wrong; the other two statements are correct

Solutions — Social Science (Class 7), Chapter 15: Empires and Kingdoms: 6th to 10th Centuries — Paper 4

Paper 4 — (progressively harder)

Marking: +4 correct, -1 wrong, 0 unattempted. Maximum marks **240**.

Answer Key

Q	Ans	Q	Ans	Q	Ans	Q	Ans	Q	Ans	Q	Ans
1	C	11	B	21	D	31	D	41	D	51	D
2	A	12	C	22	D	32	C	42	D	52	D
3	D	13	D	23	A	33	D	43	A	53	A
4	D	14	C	24	A	34	D	44	B	54	A
5	B	15	C	25	B	35	C	45	B	55	C
6	A	16	D	26	B	36	A	46	D	56	C
7	B	17	B	27	A	37	B	47	C	57	C
8	B	18	C	28	D	38	A	48	A	58	A
9	B	19	C	29	C	39	B	49	C	59	A
10	A	20	B	30	A	40	C	50	B	60	B

Answer-key distribution: A = 15, B = 15, C = 15, D = 15.

Worked Solutions

1. (C) The panel describes no single empire (fragmentation) alongside temples, universities and mathematics (cultural flowering), so the best summary pairs the two. There was no single all-India empire and certainly no suppression of learning, since the period is famous for it. Organised states plainly existed in the many regional kingdoms, and the culture was Indian and home-grown, not imposed by foreign rulers, who held only Sindh.

2. (A) The Arab conquest of Sindh was a foreign military event confined to one frontier province; it is not an Indian cultural achievement and does nothing to refute the 'dark age' charge. The rules of zero (mathematics), the Bhakti hymns (devotional literature) and the great Buddhist universities are all creative Indian achievements that do disprove the label, so they belong on the list while the conquest is the odd one out.

3. (D) The strongest support is that the period itself produced temples, universities, the rules of zero and Bhakti, which are exactly the creative achievements a 'dark age' is supposed to lack. No single emperor unified the land in this age; the achievements were Indian rather than foreign imports; and the claim of nothing lasting simply restates the discredited 'dark age' view rather than supporting the chapter's verdict.

4. (D) Competing courts wanted prestige, so each became a patron of temples and scholars, and this rivalry multiplied cultural output rather than stifling it. Fragmentation here went hand in hand with flourishing, not a halt; empires are not the only possible patrons, as the many kingdoms prove; and far from building nothing, these kingdoms left some of the age's greatest monuments.

5. (B) The barrenness claim is refuted by naming the era's universities, monolithic temple, mathematical breakthrough and devotional movement, all genuinely creative. Denying that any warfare occurred is false, since the Tripartite Struggle and southern rivalries were real; there was no single peaceful empire; and the Arabs, confined to Sindh, did not produce India's culture.

6. (A) The age is defined by powerful regional states such as the Palas, Pratiharas, Rashtrakutas and Cholas competing without any one ruling the whole, so 'many competing kingdoms, no single empire' is correct. There was no unbroken all-India empire, the many kingdoms were clearly organised states, and Arab control never reached beyond the Sindh foothold.

7. (B) The surviving temples, universities, mathematics and Bhakti hymns all date from the fragmented era itself, so culture demonstrably thrived without a single empire, supporting the second student. Building did not stop; culture was widespread rather than confined to Arab Sindh; and the evidence shows competing kingdoms, not a hidden unifying emperor.

8. (B) 606 CE comes about a hundred years before 712 CE, so Harsha's accession clearly precedes the Arab conquest of Sindh. Reversing the order ignores that 606 is the smaller number; the two are a century apart, not the same year; and 1206 marks the founding of the Delhi Sultanate, far too late to be Harsha's rise.

9. (B) If a strong heir had held the north, there would have been no need for several powers to fight over Kanauj; the very fact of the Tripartite Struggle shows the north fragmented after Harsha. No heir ruled unchallenged, the Arabs never overran the north, and the kingdoms competed rather than merging peacefully.

10. (A) A Buddhist visitor naturally took close interest in Buddhist institutions, so his detailed praise of places like Nalanda reflects his own faith, a useful caution for historians weighing his bias. He did not ignore religion; he had no reason to favour Sindh's Arabs; and he wrote in Chinese, not Tamil.

11. (B) A single traveller sees only part of a society and may idealise what matches his interests, so the sound method is to corroborate him with inscriptions, coins and local records. Accepting every word forgets these limits, rejecting it wholesale wastes useful testimony, and treating it as the only source ignores the richer body of Indian evidence.

12. (C) Relying on one observer risks importing his limits and biases, so prosperity claimed by him alone should be tested against inscriptions, coins and other records before being accepted. Xuanzang did travel through India; prosperity can indeed be studied through varied evidence; and coins are one useful source among several, not the only valid one.

13. (D) Harsha's seat of power was Kannauj on the Ganga plain, which is exactly why that city later became the prized symbol fought over in the Tripartite Struggle. Vatapi was the Chalukya capital in the Deccan, Kanchi was the Pallava capital in the Tamil south, and Ellora was a Rashtrakuta temple site, not Harsha's capital.

14. (C) It is true that no single emperor dominated the north after Harsha, and true that this opening let regional powers compete for supremacy at Kanauj; the vacuum is precisely the cause of the three-cornered contest, so the reason genuinely explains the assertion. The other choices wrongly deny the link or falsify one of the two accurate statements.

15. (C) The prefix 'tri-' means three, and the three contestants were the Palas of Bengal, the Gurjara-Pratiharas of the north-west and the Rashtrakutas of the Deccan. Naming only two forgets the Deccan power; the Tamil trio fought in the far south, not for Kanauj; and the Guptas had faded long before this contest began.

16. (D) Kanauj had become a symbol of paramount authority in the north, so seizing it announced a ruler's supremacy, a prestige worth a long campaign even from the Deccan. It was not uniquely rich in gold, the Rashtrakutas already held a strong Deccan kingdom, and Kanauj lies inland on the Ganga plain, not on any coast.

17. (B) A contest no side could finish means the rivals were roughly matched, which is the hallmark of several strong kingdoms in balance. A single empire or total peace would have ended the fighting at once, and the Arabs never ruled the north, being confined to Sindh.

18. (C) Standing on the north-western frontier, the Pratiharas absorbed and checked Arab pressure, so Arab power got no further than Sindh. They did not invite conquest, they were rivals in the Kanauj contest rather than surrenderers, and Nalanda was a Pala foundation in distant Bengal.

19. (C) The Pratiharas guarded the north-west, the Rashtrakutas held the central Deccan, and the Palas lay in Bengal to the east, a genuine west-to-east line. The other lists scramble these well-known territories or substitute the Tamil dynasties, all of which belong to the far south rather than a west-to-east sequence.

20. (B) The struggle is 'tripartite' precisely because the Deccan Rashtrakutas joined the Palas and Pratiharas in the fight, making three contestants. Limiting it to two ignores the Rashtrakutas; the Cholas contended in the far south, not at Kanauj; and the Guptas had already declined before the struggle.

21. (D) If no rival could win permanently because all were evenly matched, then the picture is of several comparable kingdoms in a shifting balance, exactly the era's pattern. A dominant empire would have settled the contest, organised armies clearly existed, and the three dynasties were independent Indian powers, not puppets of one foreign ruler.

22. (D) The Rashtrakutas built the monolithic Kailasa temple at Ellora, the Pallavas carved the rock-cut rathas at Mahabalipuram, and the Palas patronised the Buddhist university of Nalanda. The other pairings swap these famous links, for instance crediting the southern Pallavas with the Deccan's Ellora or the Bengal Palas with a Tamil-coast monument.

23. (A) 'Monolithic' means 'one stone': sculptors cut away a hillside to release a complete temple from a single rock, working top-down with no margin for error, an enormous feat of planning. Brick assembly, wood and cast iron all describe the opposite of carving from one rock and match nothing about Ellora.

24. (A) A ratha is literally a chariot, and at Mahabalipuram the Pallava sculptors carved shrines from rock in the shape of chariots. A village assembly is a sabha, a reservoir is a tank or eri, and a tribute-paying subordinate is a samanta, none of which is a temple form.

25. (B) Both monuments are rock-cut, but Kailasa is a vast complete temple released from one rock by cutting downward, a larger-scale feat than the smaller Mahabalipuram shrines. It is not brick, not a university (that describes Nalanda or Vikramashila), and it is a great temple, not a tiny chariot.

26. (B) Both monuments emerge from the stone itself rather than being assembled, so together they showcase a shared mastery of carving rock. Paper printing, paper money and steel casting are unrelated technologies and describe none of these stone monuments.

27. (A) The Pala kings supported Buddhism and the famous universities of Nalanda and Vikramashila, drawing scholars from across Asia. The Mahabalipuram rathas were Pallava work, Ellora's Kailasa was Rashtrakuta, and Sindh was the Arab foothold, none of them a Pala project.

28. (D) A scholar posted at the gate to test applicants is a screening device, which implies the institution guarded its quality and selectivity. Open admission is the opposite of what a gate-examiner implies, a gate-scholar marks a place of learning rather than an army camp, and a great university taught many subjects, not one topic.

29. (C) The Pallavas and Chalukyas were neighbouring rivals whose wars are a feature of southern politics in this age, even as both sponsored fine temple architecture. They were competitors rather than partners, ruled in the south rather than Bengal, and had nothing to do with the distant Arab conquest of Sindh.

30. (A) The Pallavas ruled from Kanchi in the Tamil country and the Chalukyas from Vatapi (Badami) in the Deccan. Swapping their capitals, or placing them in Bengal, Kashmir, Sindh or Kanauj, all misassign these two southern powers.

31. (D) The Tamil south saw the old Chola, Pandya and Chera lines revive as strong kingdoms in this period. The Palas, Pratiharas and Rashtrakutas were the northern Tripartite trio; the Mauryas, Shungas and Satavahanas belong to much earlier centuries; and the Hunas, Shakas and Kushanas were foreign-origin powers of still earlier times.

32. (C) The return of three powerful Tamil dynasties means the south was again a hub of kingdoms, temple-building and commerce. It was not empty of states, the Arabs held only Sindh far to the north-west, and the Palas ruled Bengal, not the Tamil country.

33. (D) Ratha-style rock-cut shrines on the Tamil coast point to the Pallavas of Kanchi and their work at Mahabalipuram. The Rashtrakutas built Ellora in the Deccan, the Palas patronised universities in eastern Bengal, and the Pratiharas held the distant north-west, none of which fits a Tamil-coast ratha.

34. (D) A Bengal dynasty backing a university and a southern dynasty codifying village self-rule both show separate regional powers actively building institutions of learning and governance. This contradicts the ideas that only one empire patronised culture, that kingdoms destroyed such institutions, or that civic life depended on Sindh's Arabs.

35. (C) A samanta was a lesser ruler who accepted an overlord, supplied tribute and soldiers, and governed his own territory, so the king ruled in layers rather than directly. There was no salaried daily-reporting bureaucracy reaching every region, no nationwide election, and certainly no Arab governors outside the Sindh foothold.

36. (A) Since samantas governed locally and could change sides, the overlord's power rested on their continued loyalty, making royal authority mediated rather than direct. The king did not run every village himself, samantas did owe tribute and troops, and there was no national vote in this system.

37. (B) With samantas governing regions and sabhas running villages, authority passed through intermediate hands rather than reaching each person directly from the king. A king touching every villager directly contradicts the layered system, the Arabs held only Sindh, and there was no national parliament in this age.

38. (A) The Uttaramerur inscriptions set out the actual qualifications and selection rules for the village sabha, making them the direct evidence for Chola local government.

Xuanzang described the north a century or more earlier, Brahmagupta wrote on mathematics, and the Rajatarangini concerns Kashmir's dynasties, none of which addresses Chola village assemblies.

39. (B) A land grant transferred land or its revenues to a recipient such as a brahmana, temple or official, and over time produced a stratum of landholders, which is why these grants matter to social history. It did not strip villagers of everything, and a devotional poem and a rock-cut shrine are entirely different things.

40. (C) Self-governing village assemblies meant ordinary affairs were handled locally, so there was genuine local self-rule under the kings. This contradicts the idea of no government below the king, rule only by foreigners, or a single national parliament, none of which fits the layered politics of the age.

41. (D) A sabha is the self-governing village assembly and a samanta is a tribute-paying subordinate ruler, two pillars of the layered politics of the age. Swapping the two, or equating them with a temple, reservoir, poem or pilgrim, misdefines both terms.

42. (D) An eri was an artificial reservoir that captured rain for farming and household needs, evidence of careful water management. It was not a chariot, a monastery, or a subordinate ruler; those are unrelated things drawn from elsewhere in the chapter.

43. (A) Organised guilds and thriving towns are marks of a working, prosperous economy, so they refute the 'dark age' picture. A ruined economy would lack guilds and towns, barter-only trade would not need guilds, and the Arabs, confined to Sindh, did not control the subcontinent's commerce.

44. (B) Grants organised landholding, guilds organised trade, and tanks organised water, so together they describe a managed, productive economy. Ruin, the absence of trade, or the absence of landholders each contradict at least one of these three institutions.

45. (B) A guild repairing a reservoir and a grant funding a temple show trade bodies, water management and land grants operating together, the signs of a managed, prosperous economy. The very record disproves any claim of no trade, collapse, or Arab control, since these are clearly active Indian institutions.

46. (D) Scholars arriving from across Asia show that India's universities had international standing and that travel and exchange flourished, contradicting any picture of isolation. India was not cut off, it plainly had great institutions of study, and the Arabs held only Sindh, not the whole land.

47. (C) Examples like the Palas' rise and the regional variation of jatis show that social position was not frozen, so the 'completely rigid' label is wrong. The chapter does not deny that jatis existed, claim a single uniform group, or say caste was abolished, only that it could shift.

- 48. (A)** The Kayasthas illustrate occupational groups becoming recognised jatis, showing that the social order was still forming and changing. This is the opposite of an unchangeable jati and has nothing to do with foreign rule or rock-cut temples.
- 49. (C)** Multiplying jatis and changing status are signs of a system in flux, so it was complex and evolving rather than fixed. It was neither simple-and-static, nor abolished, nor uniform everywhere, since regional variety is part of the point.
- 50. (B)** The chapter stresses that status could shift and jatis varied by region, so the right correction is that caste was flexible and regionally varied. Calling it rigid keeps the error, caste was not abolished, and there was no single uniform group, since the very point is its diversity.
- 51. (D)** Evidence of influential queens shows women could wield real authority in this period. They were neither wholly absent nor universally barred, but nor did any single woman rule the entire subcontinent, which would overstate the case.
- 52. (D)** Bhakti centred on a direct, emotional bond between worshipper and god and welcomed people regardless of status, setting it apart from the priest-led sacrifices of earlier practice. It was not sacrifice-based, not restricted to royalty, and not an Arab import.
- 53. (A)** The Alvars sang of Vishnu and the Nayanars of Shiva, both in Tamil, a standard pairing. Swapping their deities, making them both Buddhist, or turning them into pilgrims and generals all misidentify these Tamil devotional poets.
- 54. (A)** Brahmagupta gave systematic rules for using zero in arithmetic, a landmark contribution that further disproves the 'dark age' idea. The Rajatarangini was Kalhana's work, the Sindh conquest was an Arab military event, and the Alvars were Tamil devotional poets, none of them Brahmagupta.
- 55. (C)** A major advance in mathematics during these centuries is direct proof of intellectual vitality, so it specifically rebuts the 'dark age' charge. The other three statements are themselves correct facts, not claims that the rules of zero are used to refute.
- 56. (C)** Epigraphy reads inscriptions cut into stone or metal, which preserve grants, genealogies and village rules from this period. Coins are the field of numismatics, stars belong to astronomy, and travel diaries are a separate kind of literary source.
- 57. (C)** Royal inscriptions glorify their own patron, so conflicting claims signal bias on both sides, and the historian must cross-check them against other sources. Length does not prove truth, both records still hold useful clues rather than being worthless, and mere age does not guarantee accuracy.

- 58. (A)** Kalhana's *Rajatarangini* is a rare attempt at ordered, historical narrative, a chronicle of Kashmir's kings, which is why it stands out among early Indian texts. It is not a mathematics treatise, a devotional poem, or an Arab account of Sindh.
- 59. (A)** The accurate picture is a foothold in Sindh from 712 that Indian powers prevented from growing. The Arabs did not conquer all India, they did hold Sindh so they were not wholly excluded, and they never ruled Bengal or the Tamil south.
- 60. (B)** Each statement fails a key fact: the age was creative rather than dark, the Arabs took only Sindh rather than most of India, and the Tripartite Struggle involved three powers rather than two, so all three are wrong. The options that count fewer errors leave at least one false claim standing, which the chapter's evidence contradicts.